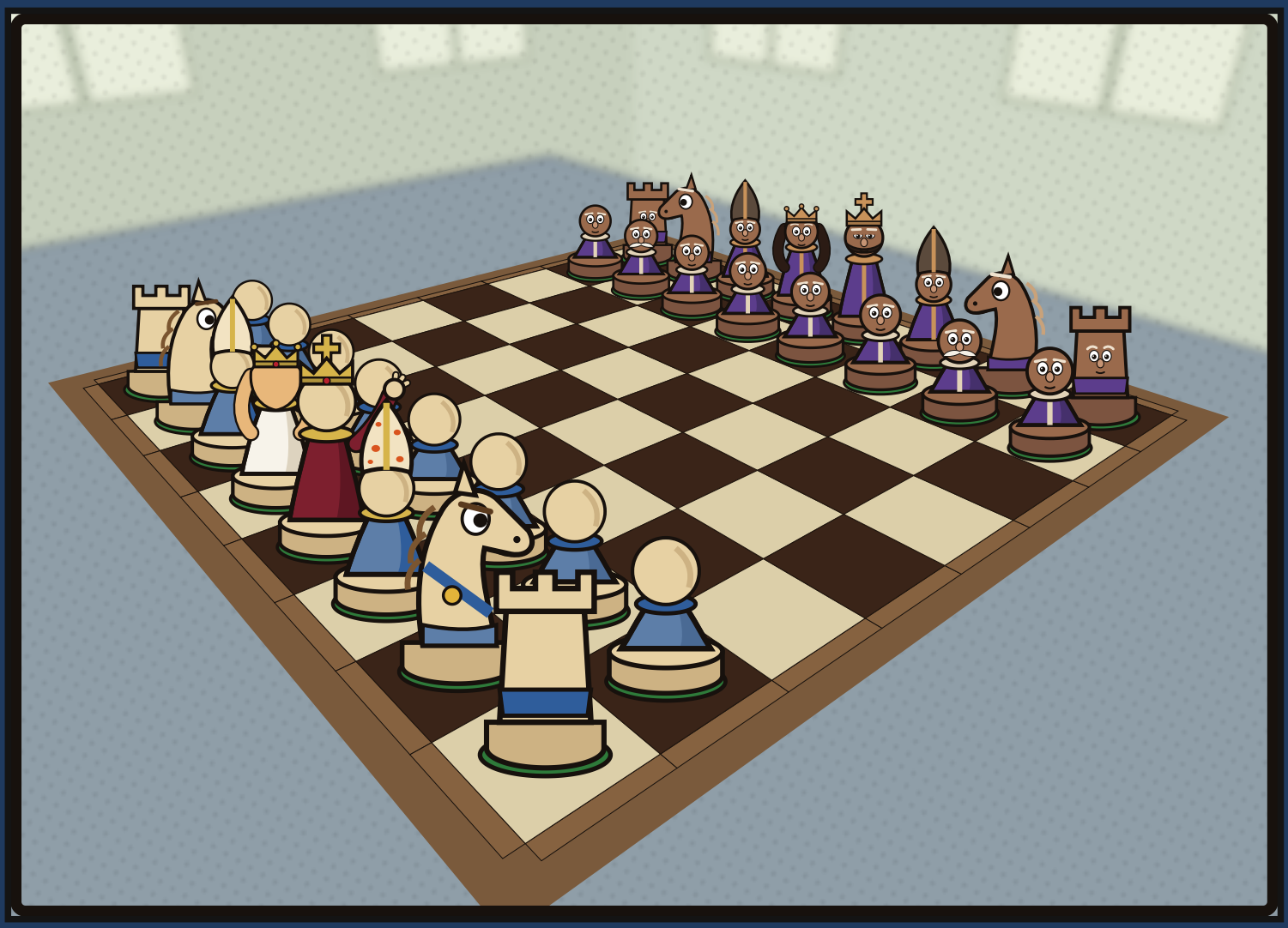
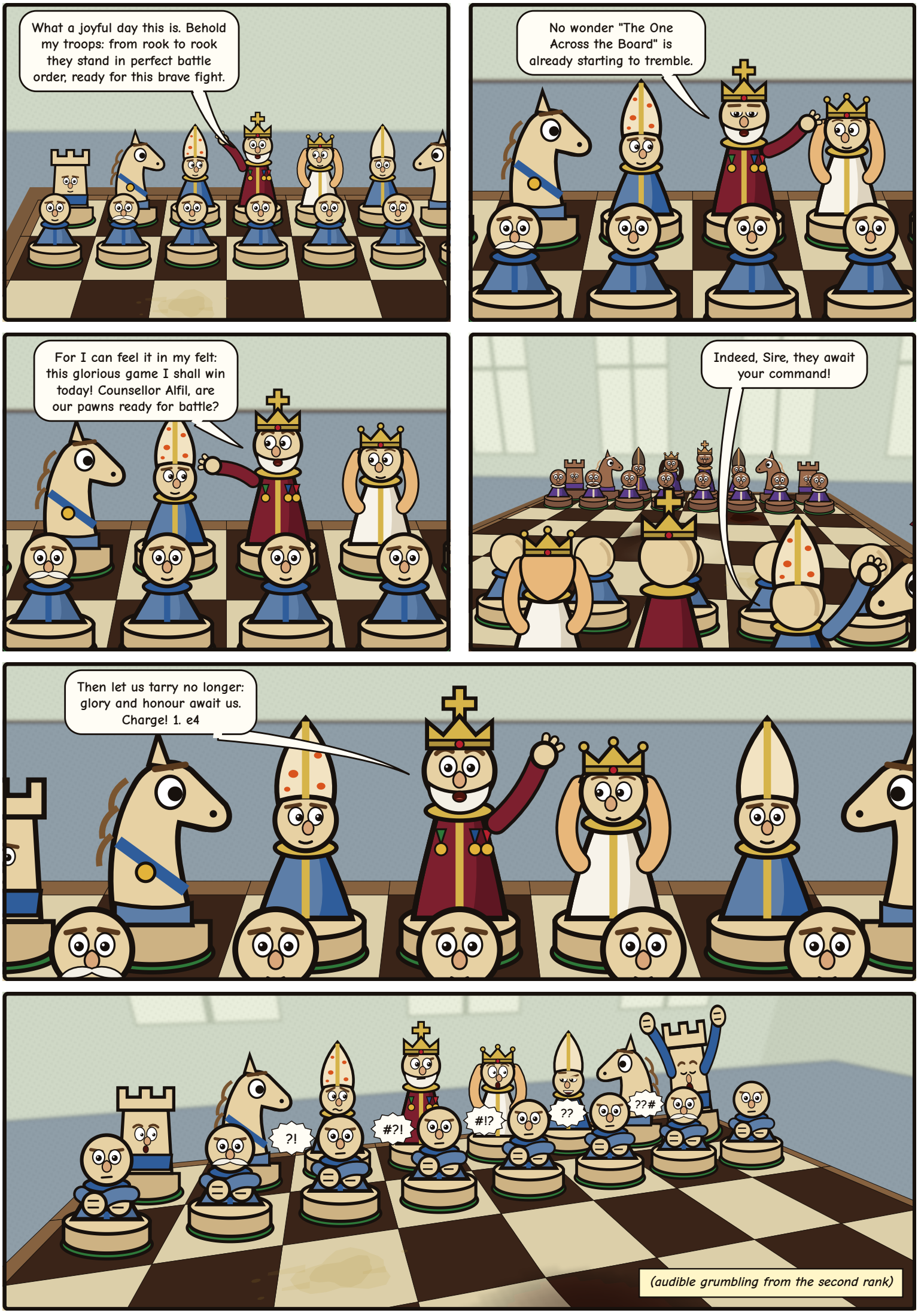
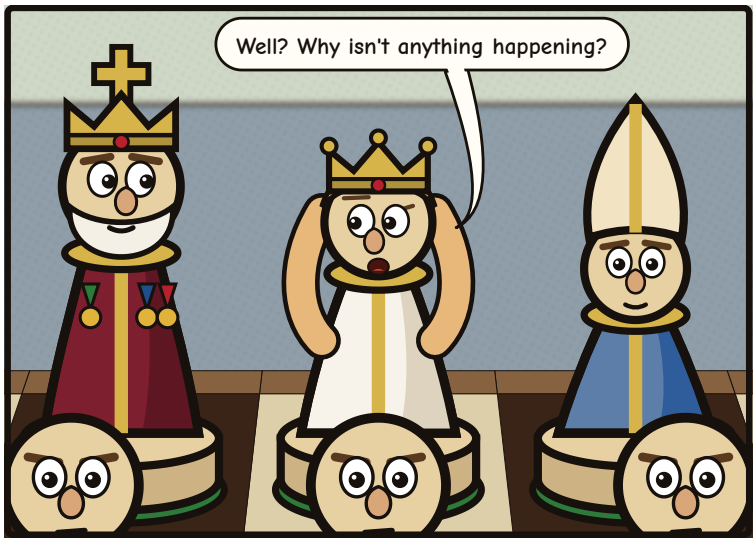
The Miniature

A Modern Farce in One Act



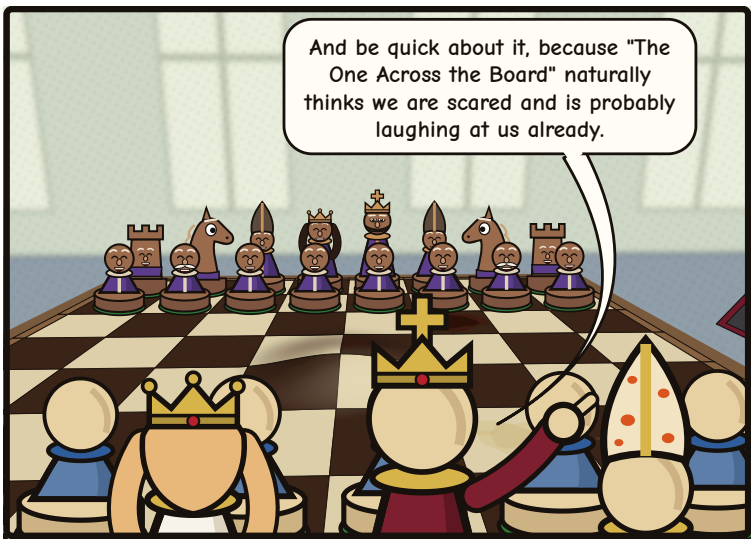
S. Gorts

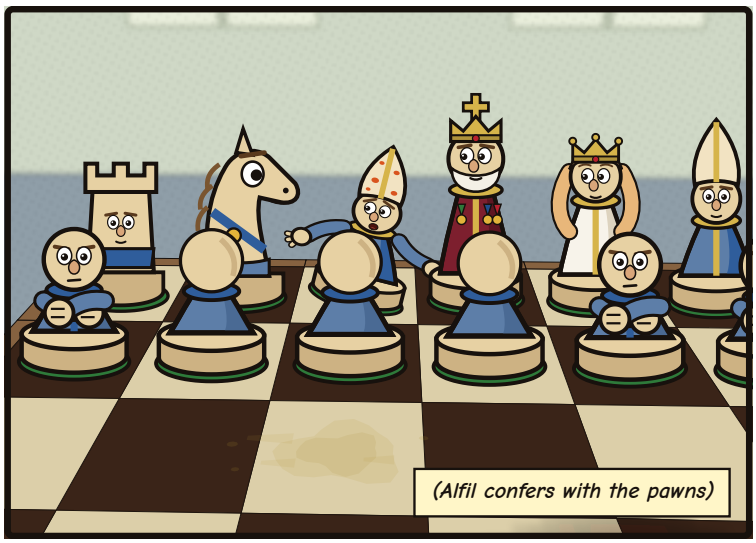

What a joyful day this is. Behold my troops: from rook to rook they stand in perfect battle order, ready for this brave fight.
No wonder "The One Across the Board" is already starting to tremble.
For I can feel it in my felt: this glorious game I shall win today! Counsellor Alfil, are our pawns ready for battle?
Indeed, Sire, they await your command!
Then let us tarry no longer: glory and honour await us. Charge! 1. e4
?!
#?!
#!?
??
??#
(audible grumbling from the second rank)

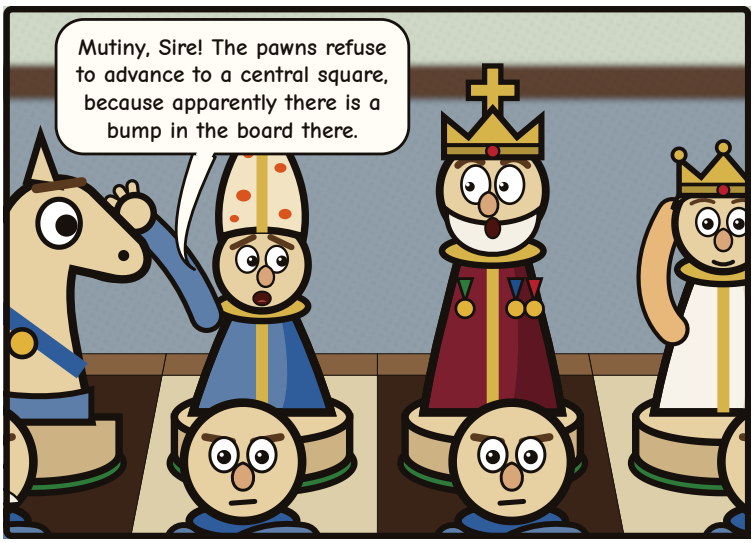

Well? Why isn't anything happening?

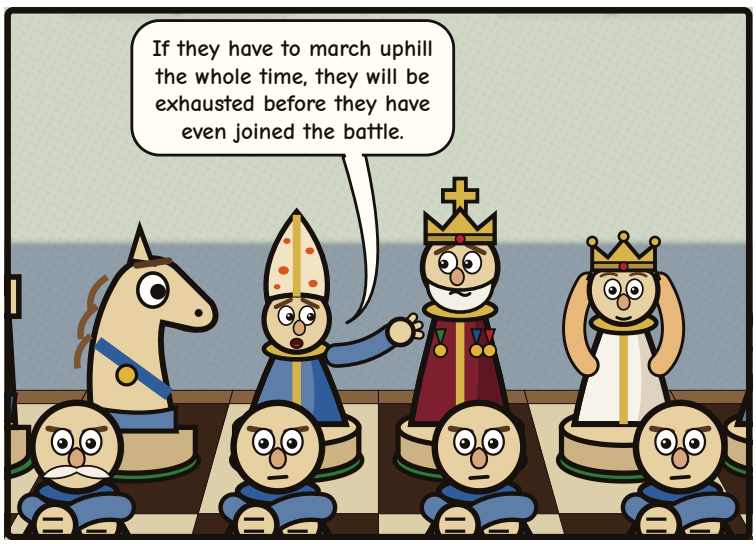

Alfil, my counsellor, you know that as king I do not speak to that lowly peasant folk.
Z
Z
z


Ask those lazybones on the second rank what the matter is.
Z
Z
z

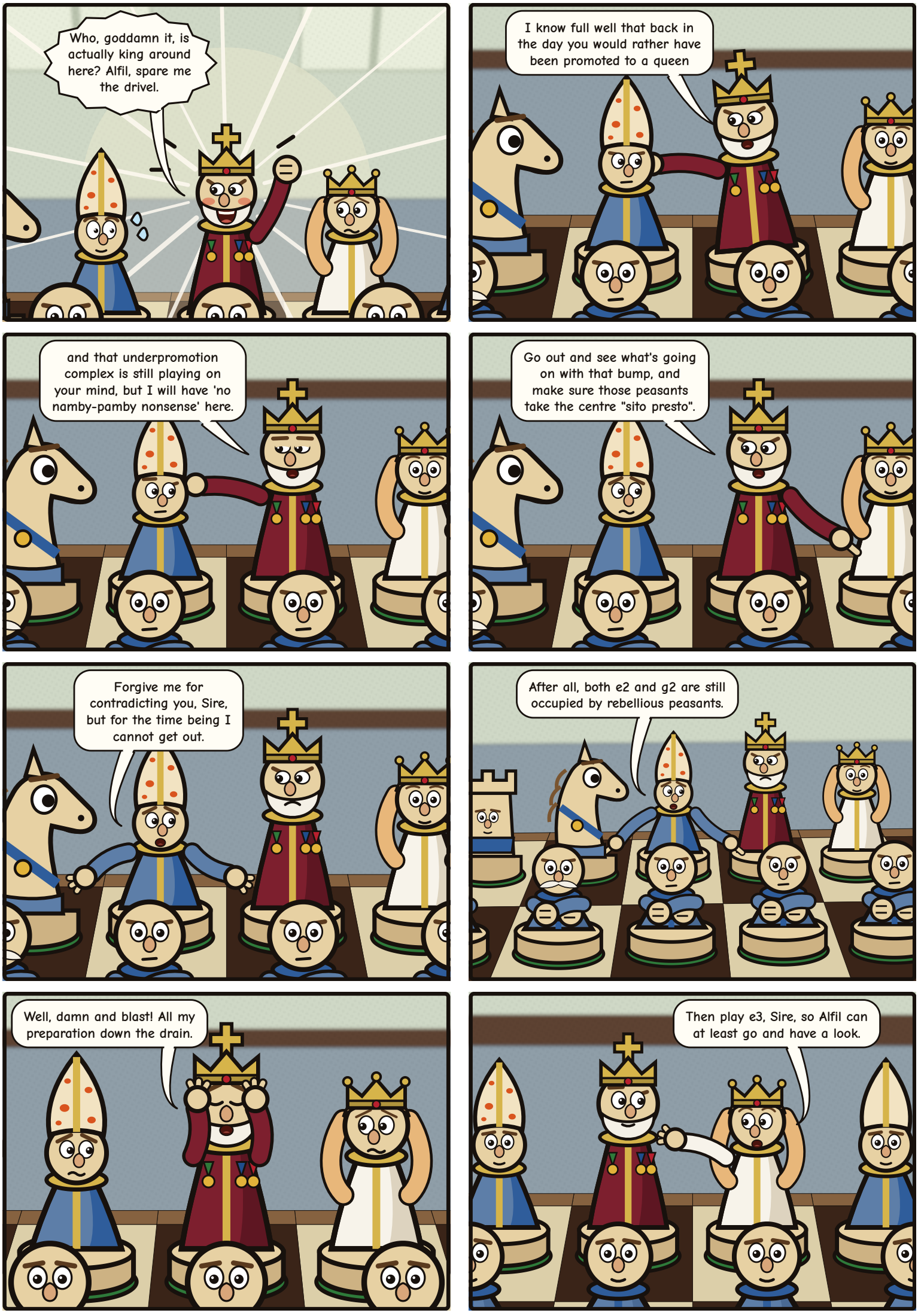

And be quick about it, because "The One Across the Board" naturally thinks we are scared and is probably laughing at us already.

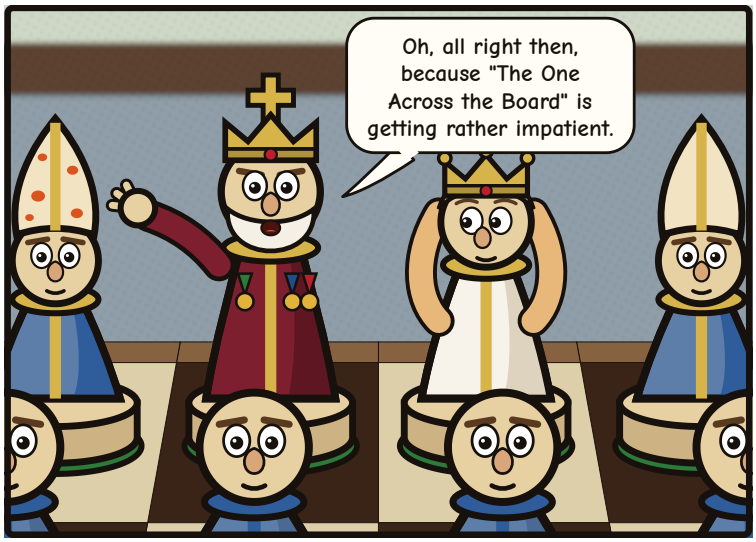

(Alfil confers with the pawns)

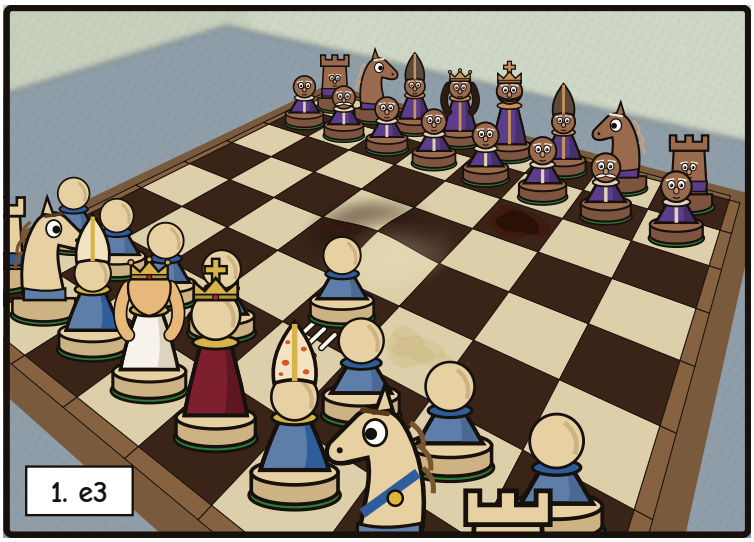

Mutiny, Sire! The pawns refuse to advance to a central square, because apparently there is a bump in the board there.

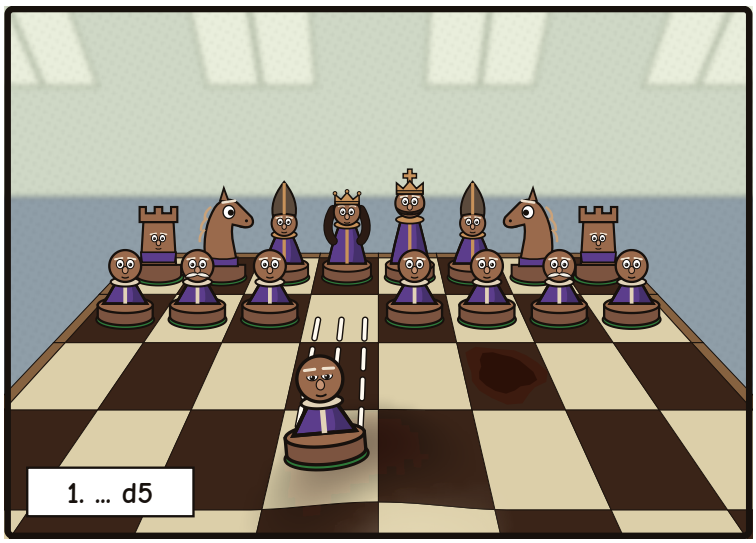

If they have to march uphill the whole time, they will be exhausted before they have even joined the battle.


If you wish to win the game today, you will have to play something else.

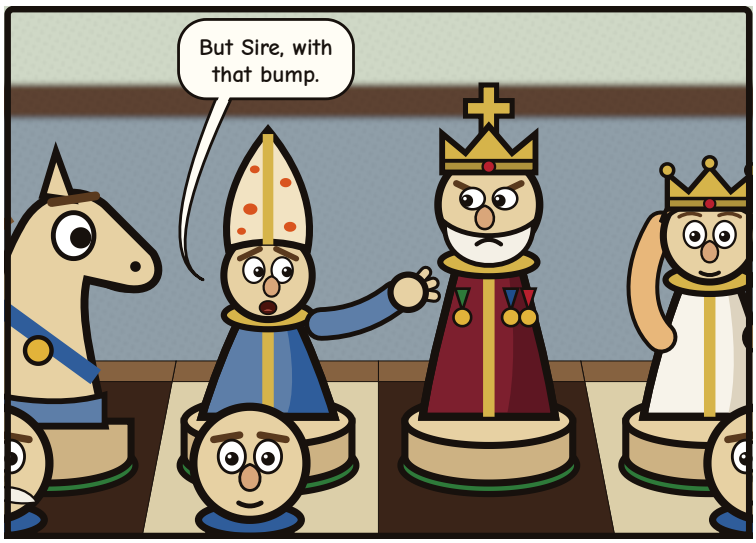

Who, goddamn it, is actually king around here? Alfil, spare me the drivel.
I know full well that back in the day you would rather have been promoted to a queen
and that underpromotion complex is still playing on your mind, but I will have 'no namby-pamby nonsense' here.
Go out and see what's going on with that bump, and make sure those peasants take the centre "sito presto".
Forgive me for contradicting you, Sire, but for the time being I cannot get out.
After all, both e2 and g2 are still occupied by rebellious peasants.
Well, damn and blast! All my preparation down the drain.
Then play e3, Sire, so Alfil can at least go and have a look.

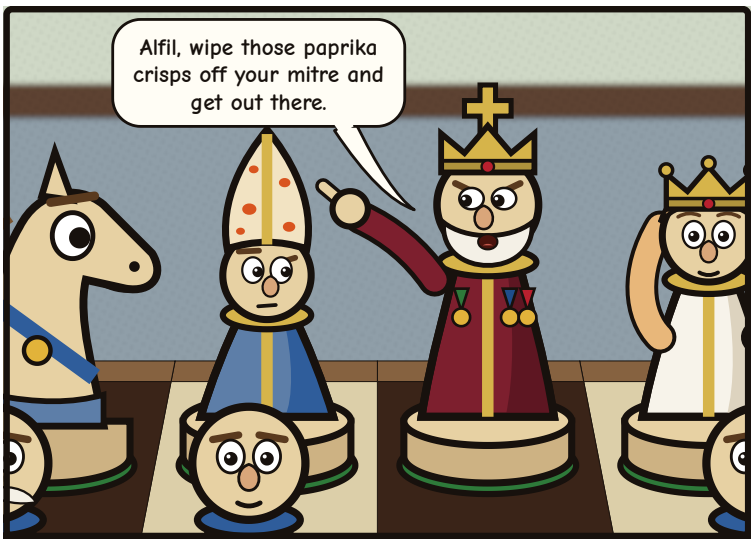

Oh, all right then, because "The One Across the Board" is getting rather impatient.

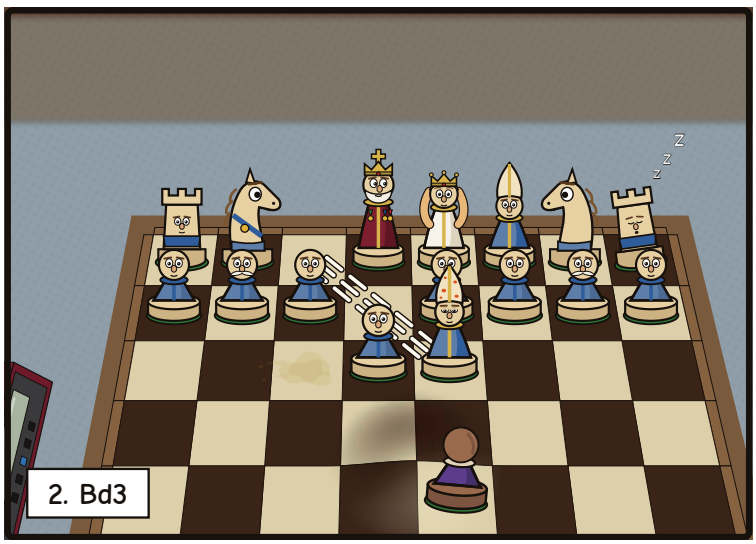

1. e3

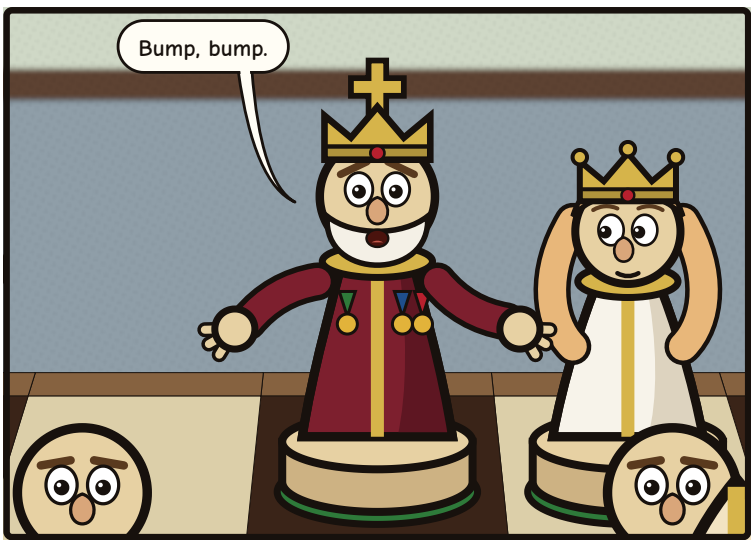

1. ... d5

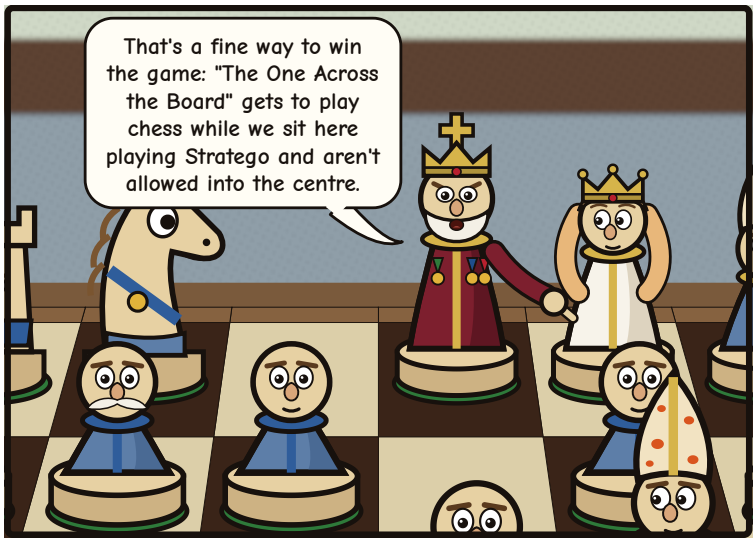

There you go, see? What did I tell you? "The One Across the Board" is grabbing the centre straight away.


But Sire, with that bump.

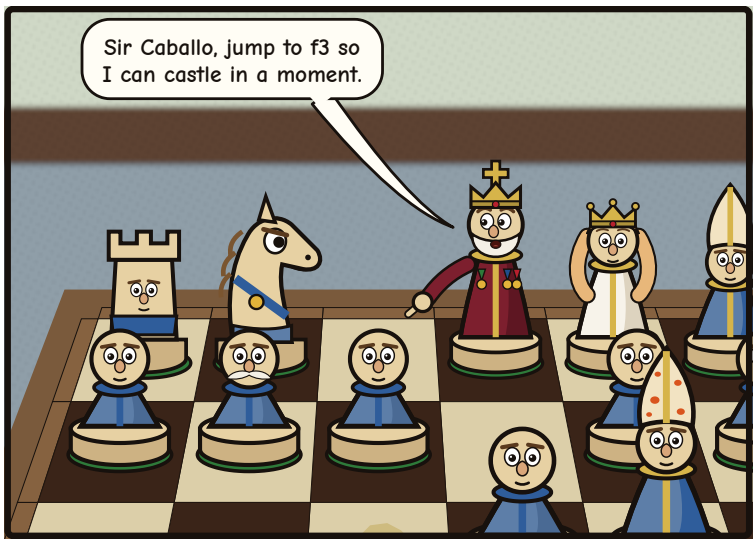

Alfil, wipe those paprika crisps off your mitre and get out there.

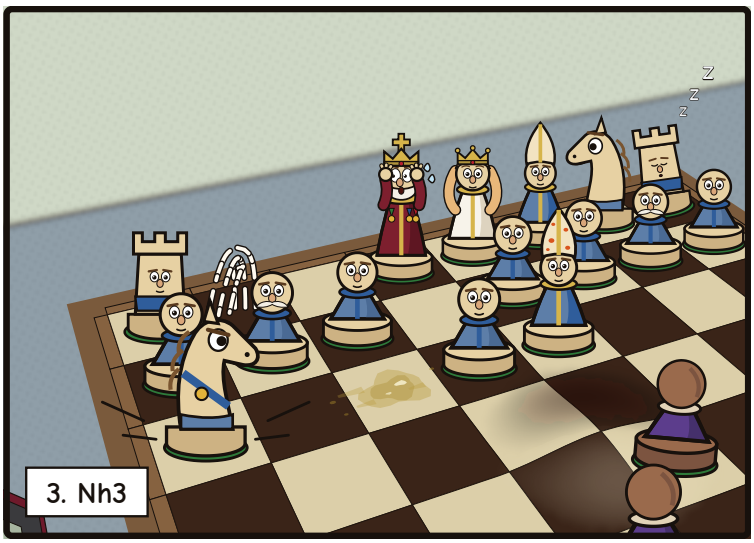

2. Bd3

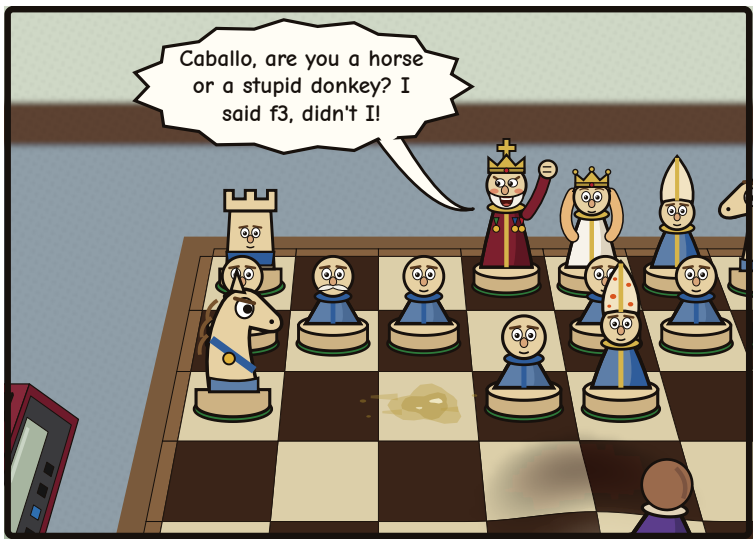

Bump, bump.


That's a fine way to win the game: "The One Across the Board" gets to play chess while we sit here playing Stratego and aren't allowed into the centre.


2. ... e6

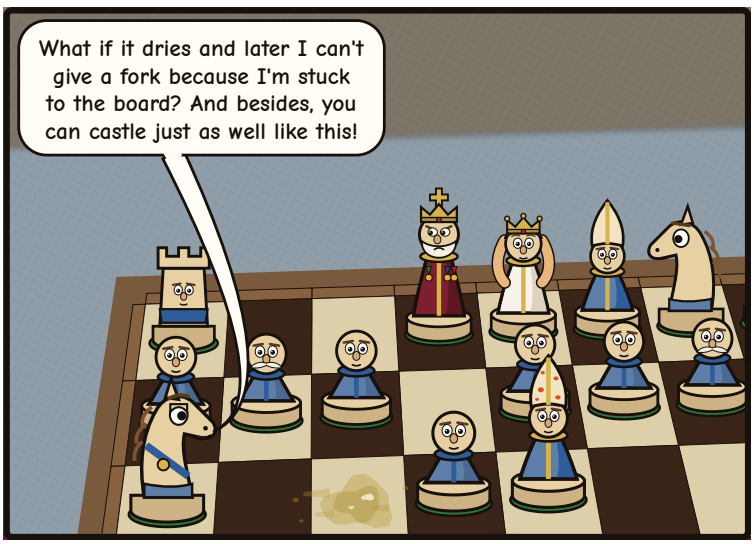

Sir Caballo, jump to f3 so I can castle in a moment.

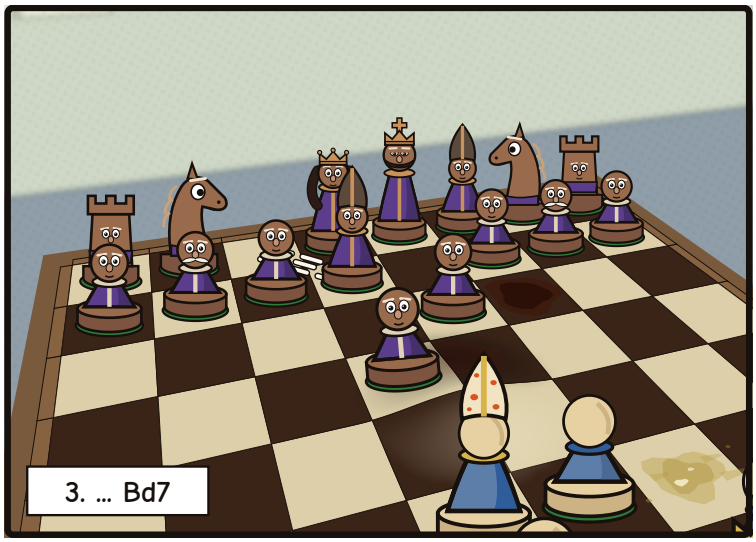

3. Nh3

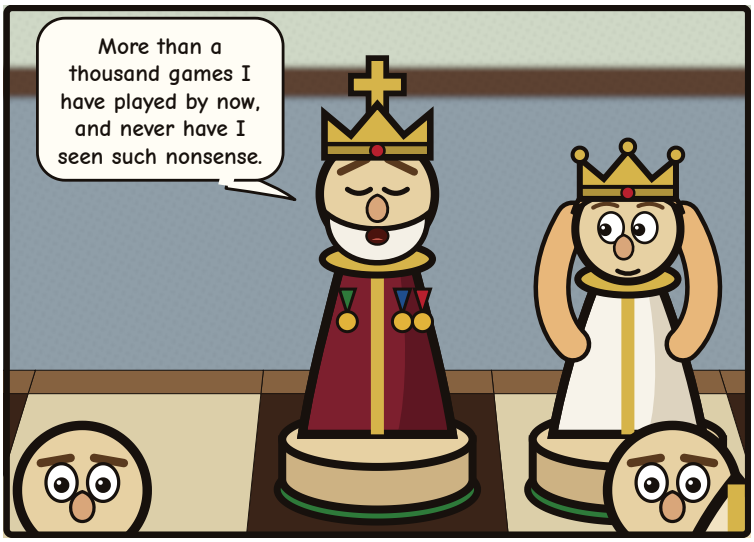

Caballo, are you a horse or a stupid donkey? I said f3, didn't I!

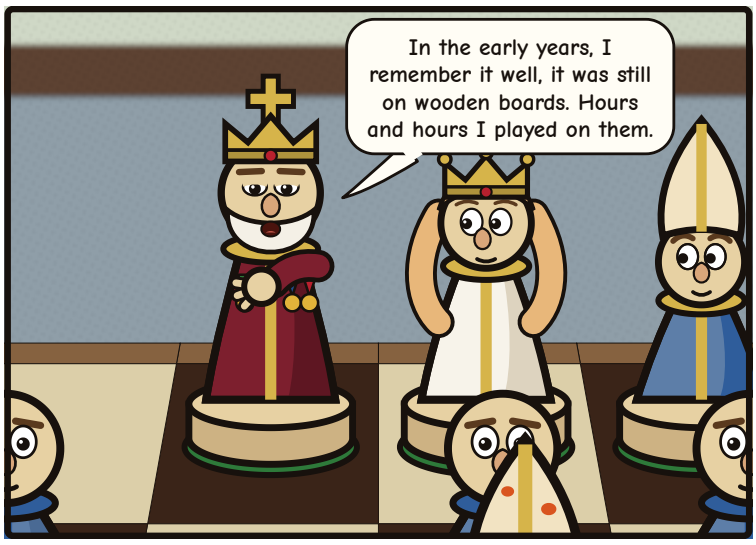

Stand on that filthy square, in that greasy spot? Out of the question, Sire!

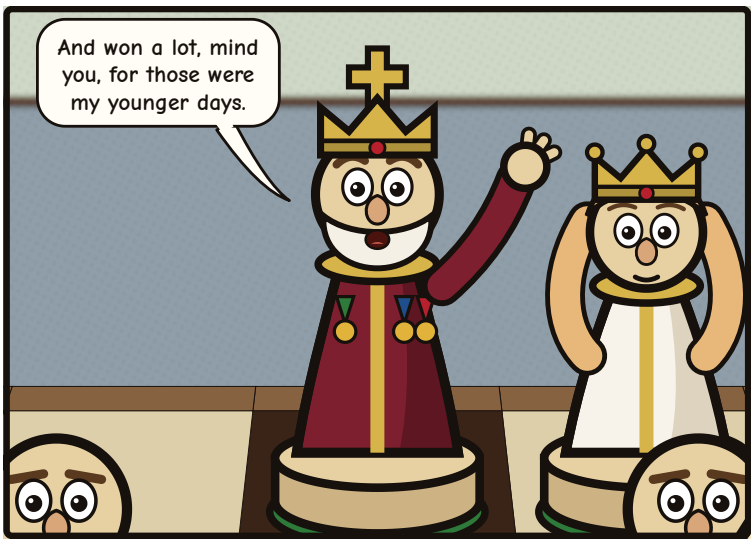

Driving your foot soldiers through it is one thing, but you do not leave an officer to rot with his base in such a filthy, dirty spot.

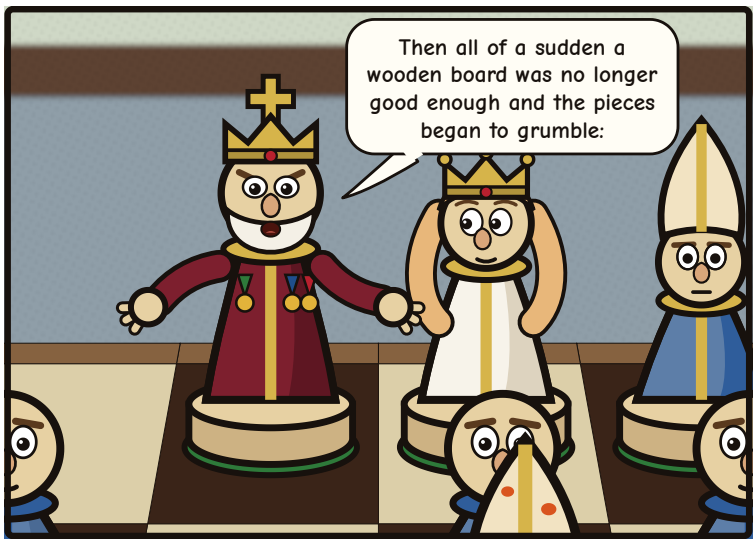

What if it dries and later I can't give a fork because I'm stuck to the board? And besides, you can castle just as well like this!

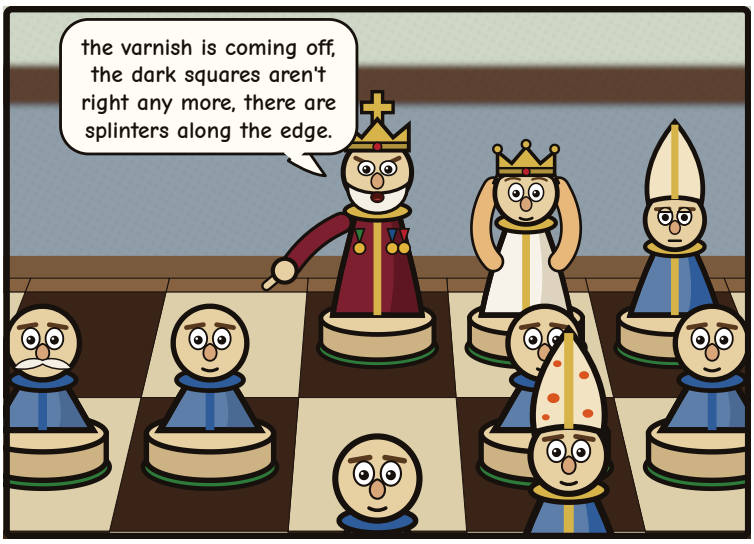

3. ... Bd7


More than a thousand games I have played by now, and never have I seen such nonsense.

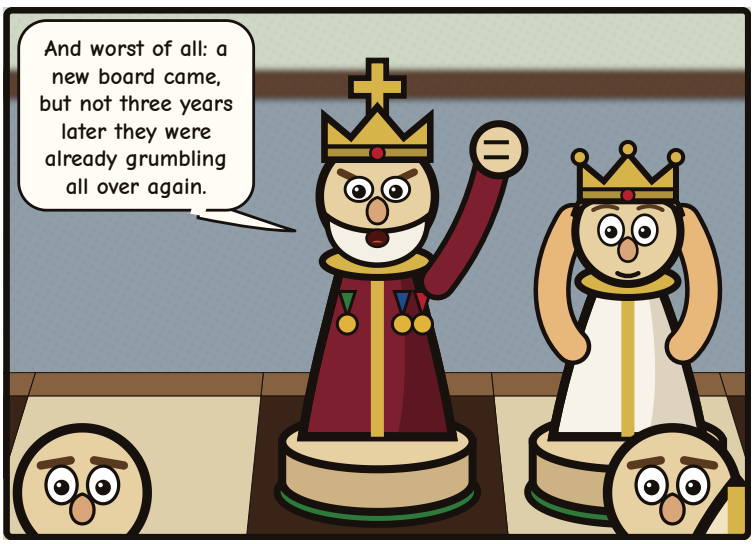

In the early years, I remember it well, it was still on wooden boards. Hours and hours I played on them.

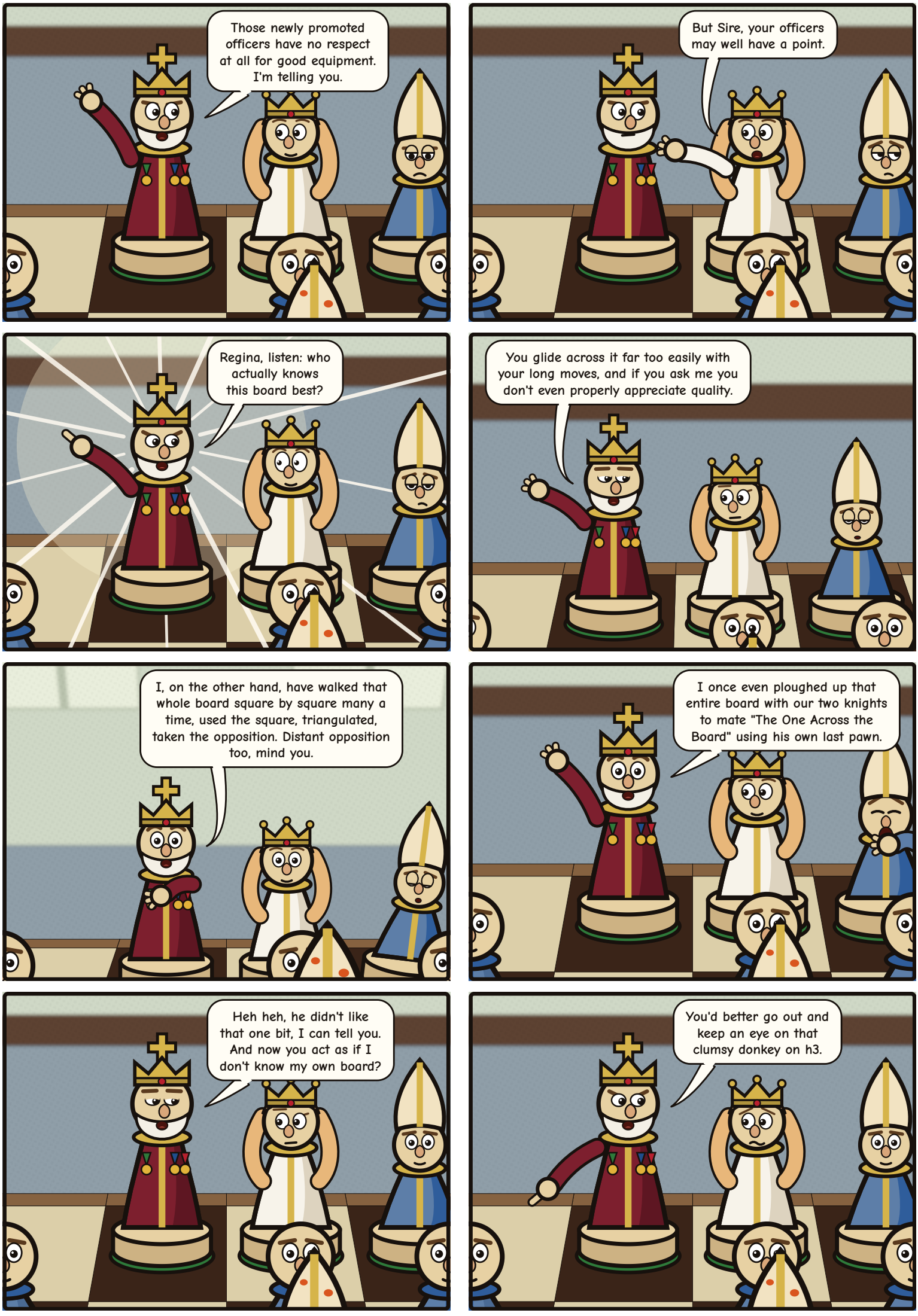

And won a lot, mind you, for those were my younger days.

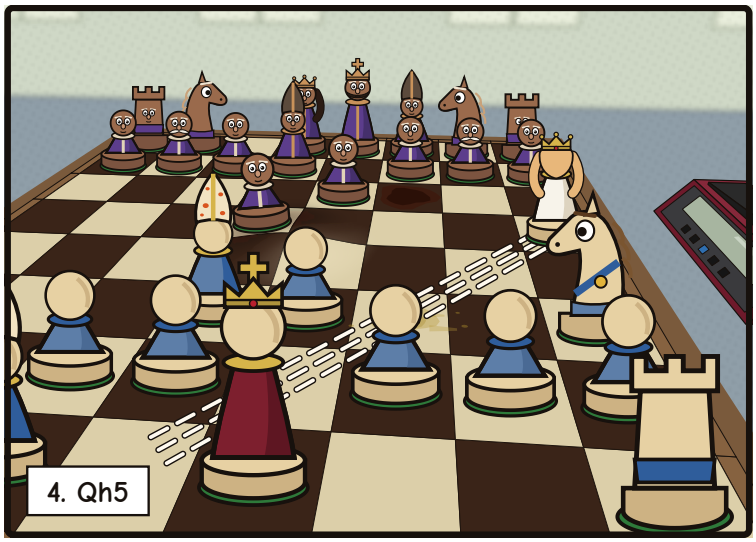

Then all of a sudden a wooden board was no longer good enough and the pieces began to grumble:

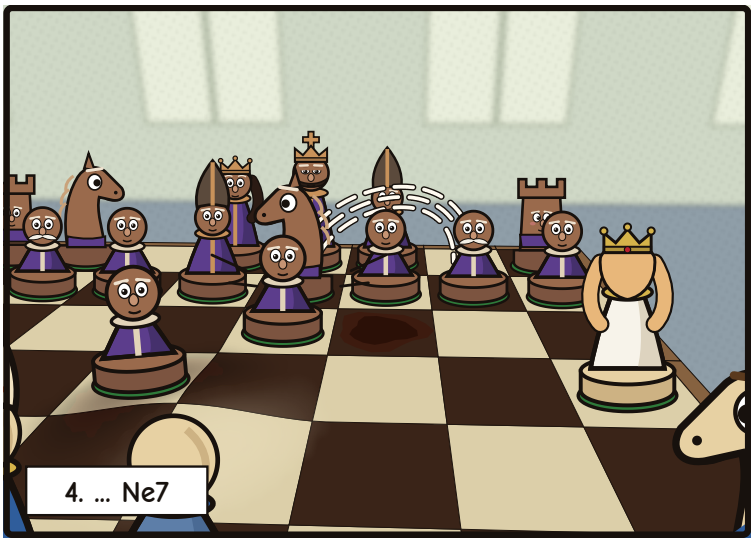

the varnish is coming off, the dark squares aren't right any more, there are splinters along the edge.

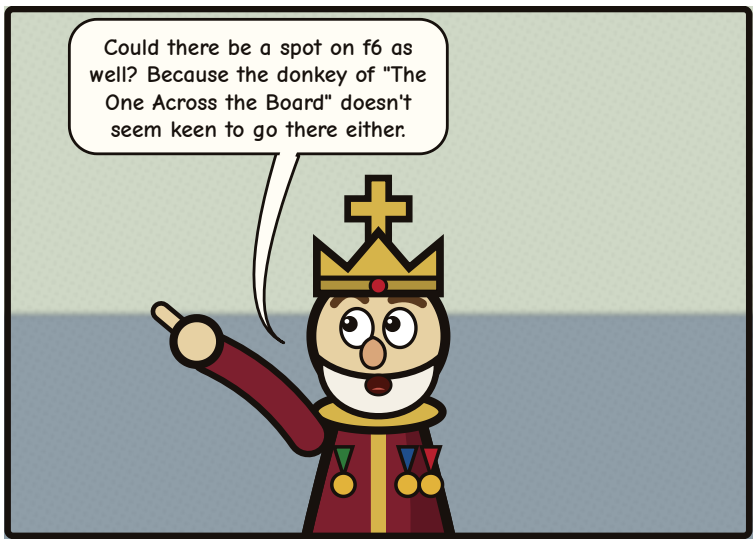

Anyway, they refused to play on it any longer, and the sooner the better it had to be one of those modern plastic ones.


And worst of all: a new board came, but not three years later they were already grumbling all over again.

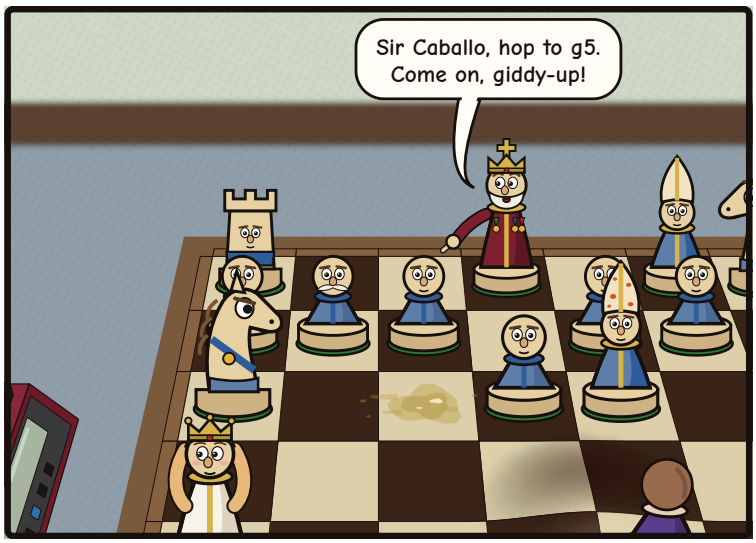

Those newly promoted officers have no respect at all for good equipment. I'm telling you.
But Sire, your officers may well have a point.
Regina, listen: who actually knows this board best?
You glide across it far too easily with your long moves, and if you ask me you don't even properly appreciate quality.
I, on the other hand, have walked that whole board square by square many a time, used the square, triangulated, taken the opposition. Distant opposition too, mind you.
I once even ploughed up that entire board with our two knights to mate "The One Across the Board" using his own last pawn.
Heh heh, he didn't like that one bit, I can tell you. And now you act as if I don't know my own board?
You'd better go out and keep an eye on that clumsy donkey on h3.

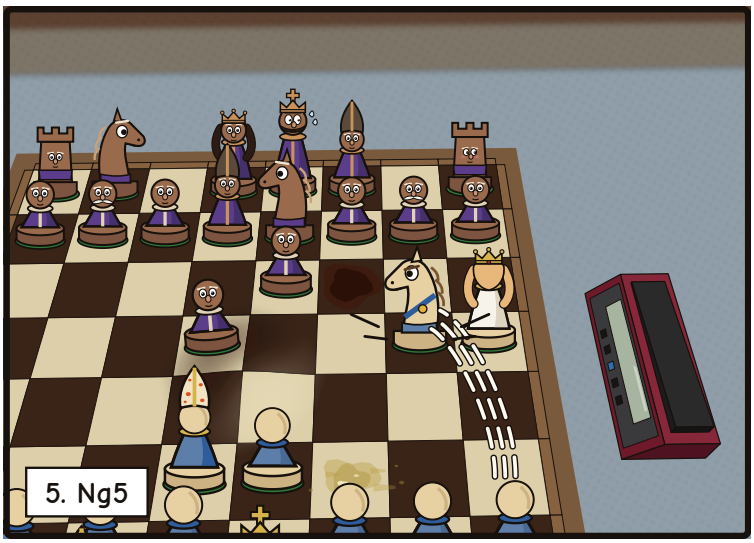

4. Qh5

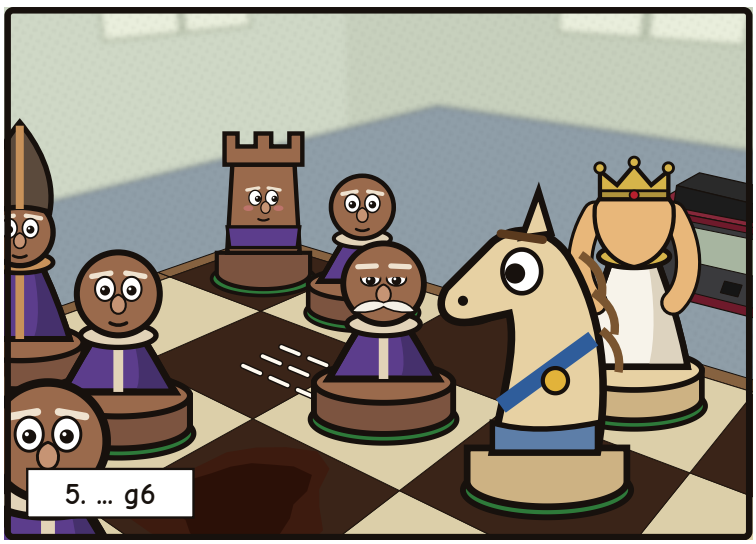

4. ... Ne7


Could there be a spot on f6 as well? Because the donkey of "The One Across the Board" doesn't seem keen to go there either.

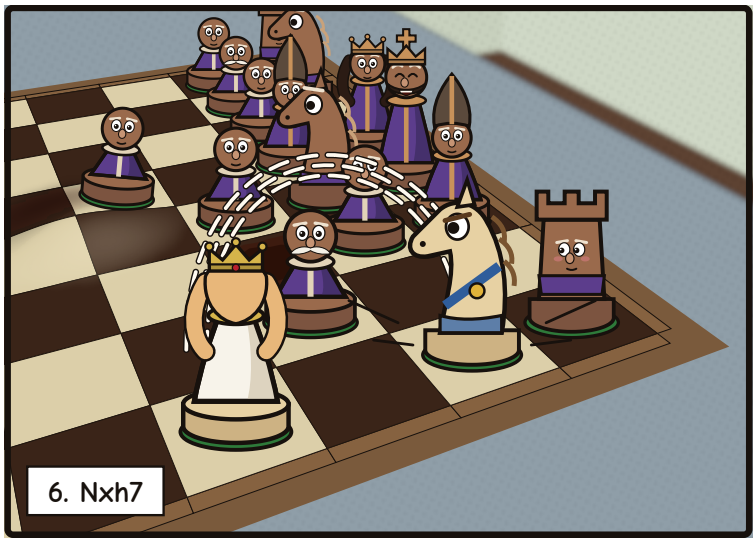

Hey, wait a minute ... .


Sir Caballo, hop to g5. Come on, giddy-up!

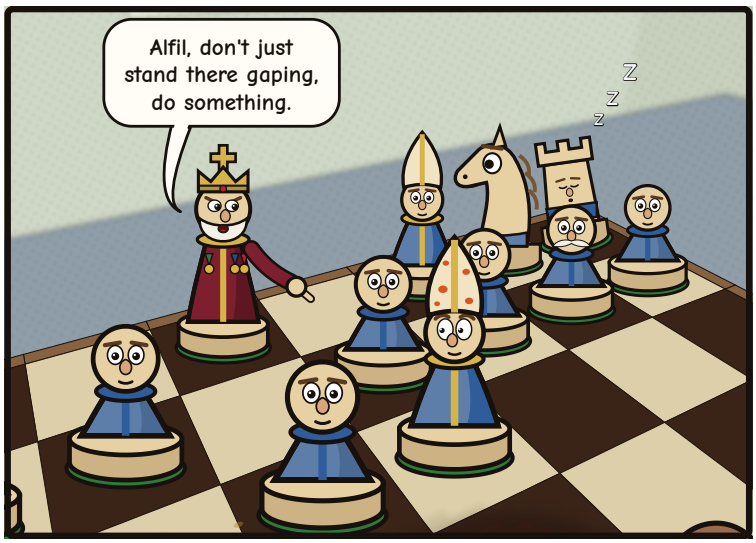

5. Ng5


5. ... g6

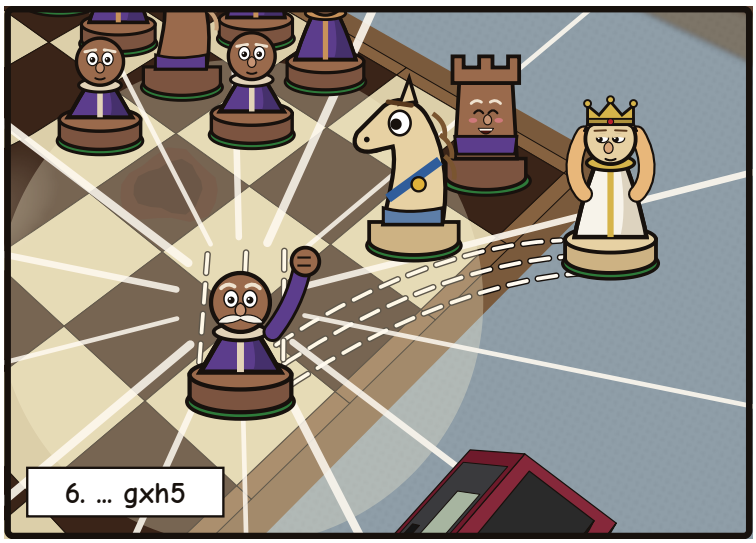

For glory and victory! Charge!


6. Nxh7

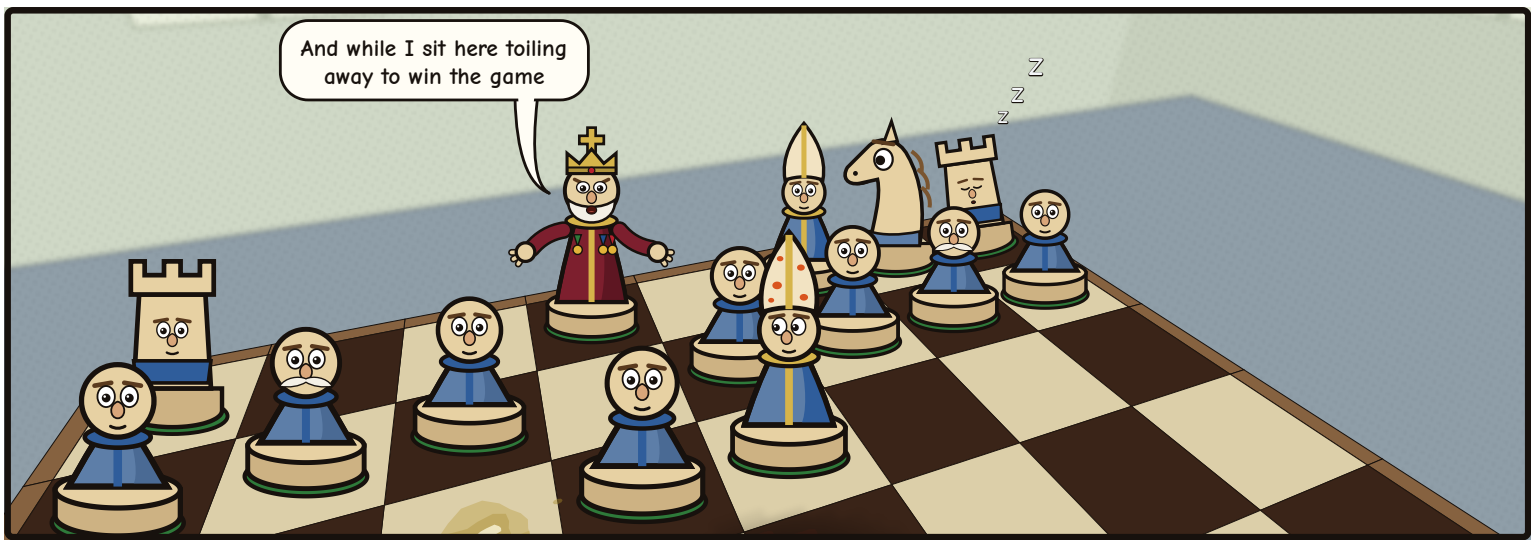

Goddamn it, Caballo, you stupid donkey! How many times must I tell you that I am the one in command during the game.

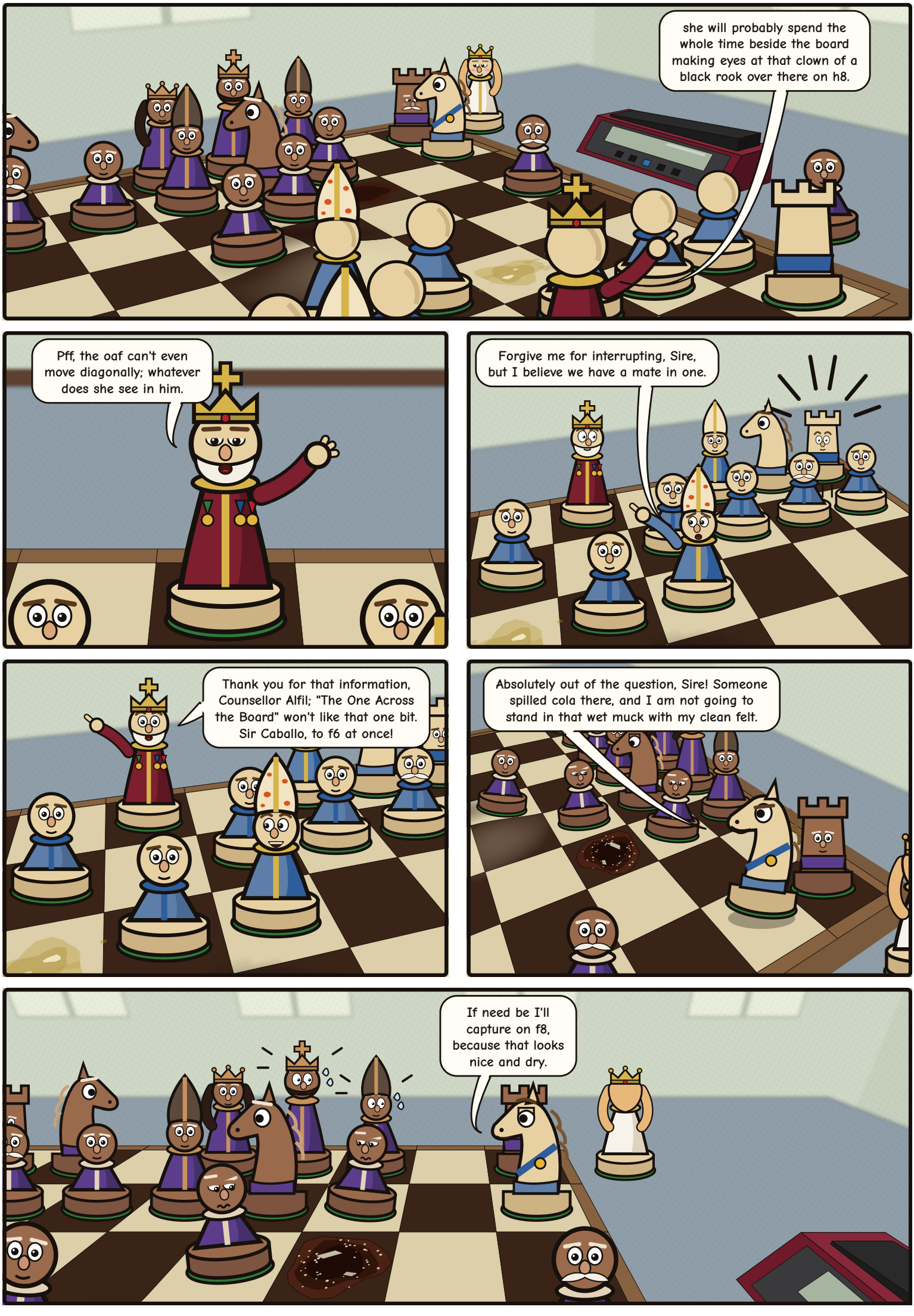

Alfil, don't just stand there gaping, do something.
Z
Z
z

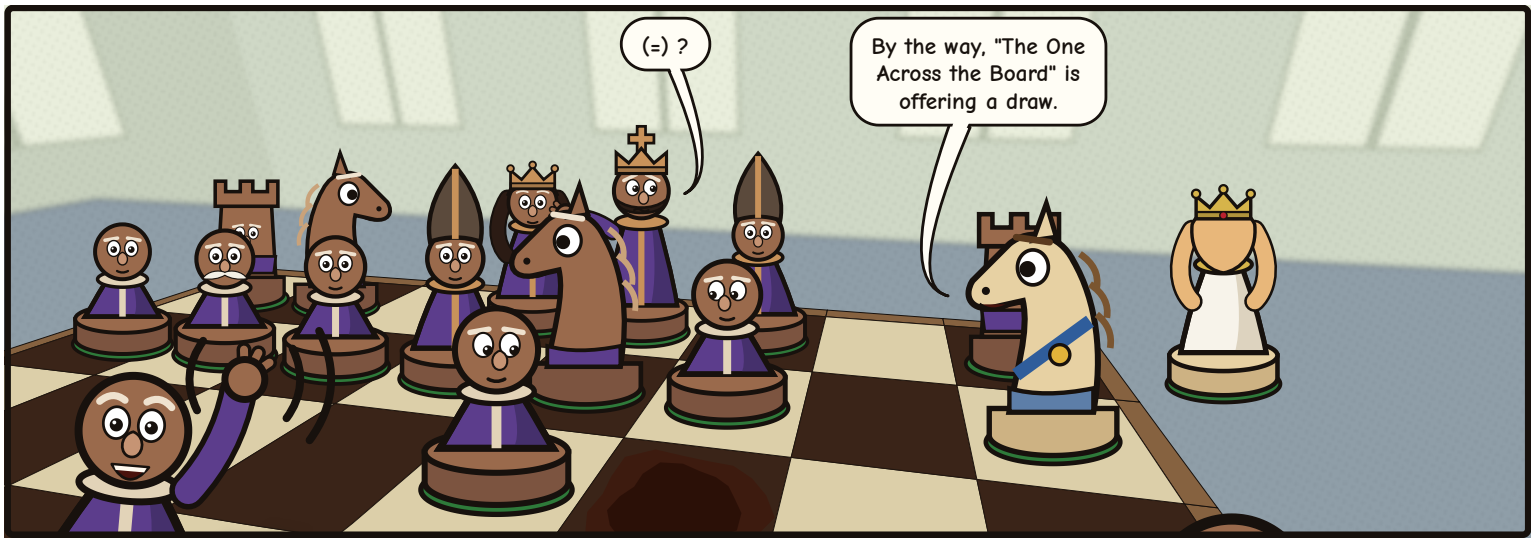

Regina is hanging, surely you can see that yourself? Damn and blast it, "The One Across the Board" is already to move.

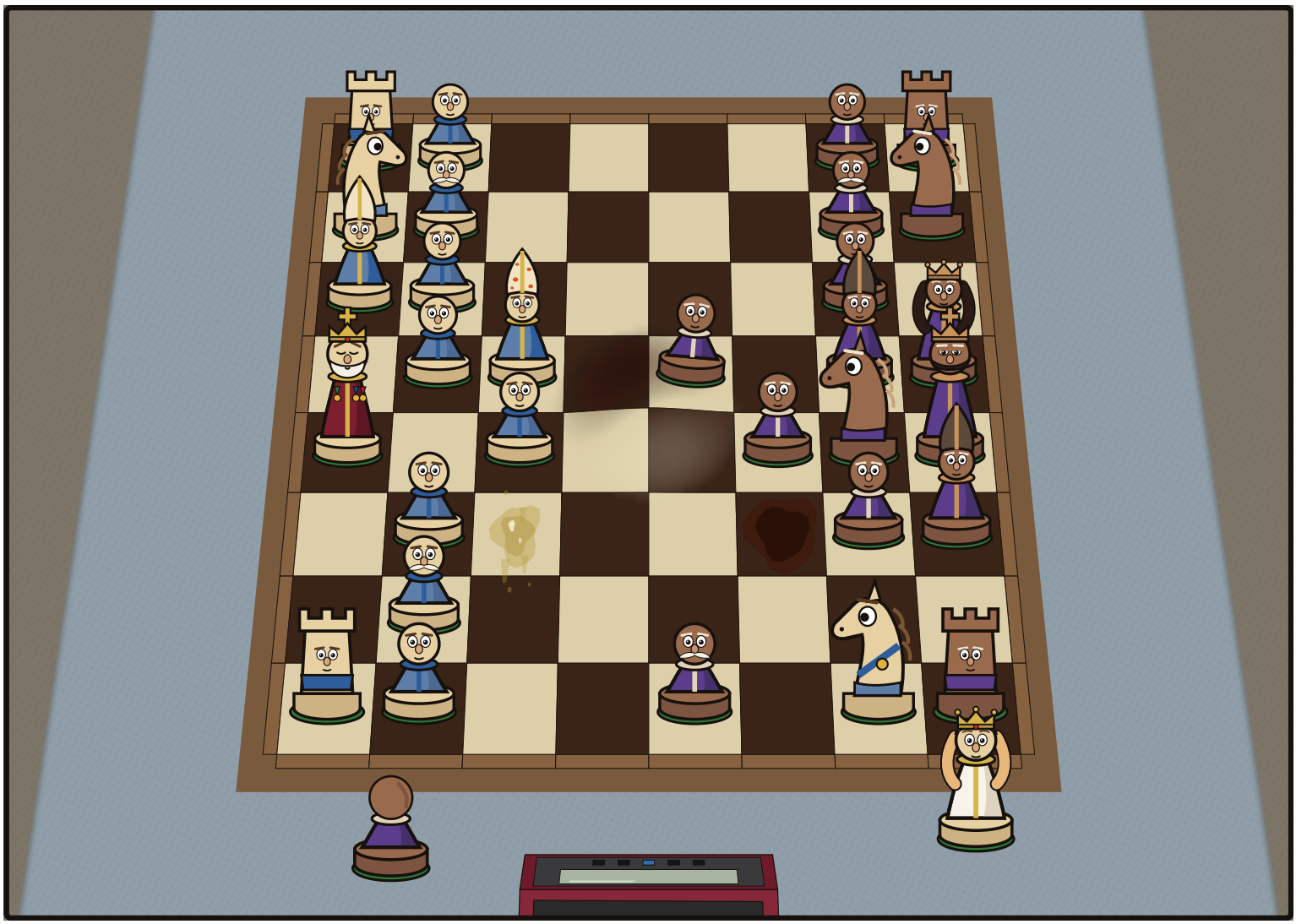

6. ... gxh5

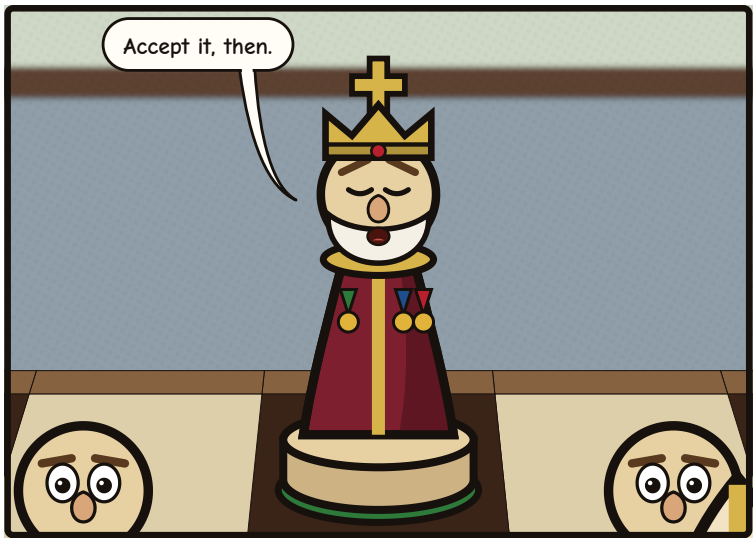

There you go, there it is. Regina captured.

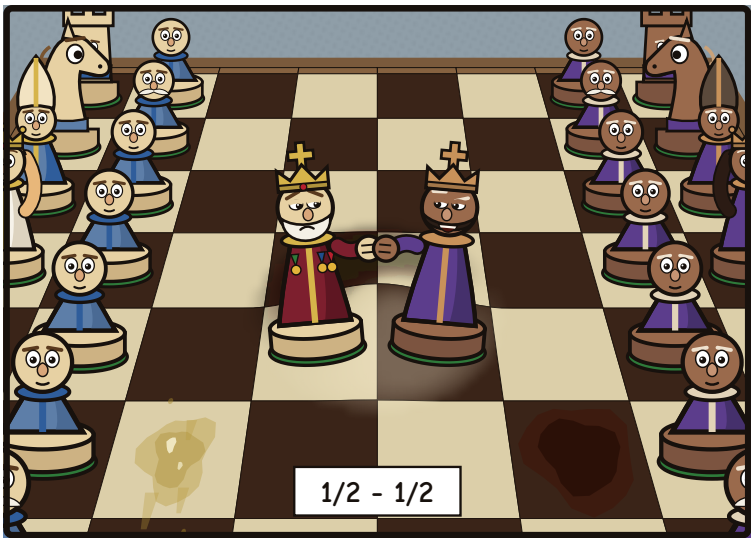

And while I sit here toiling away to win the game
Z
Z
z


she will probably spend the whole time beside the board making eyes at that clown of a black rook over there on h8.
Pff, the oaf can't even move diagonally; whatever does she see in him.
Forgive me for interrupting, Sire, but I believe we have a mate in one.
Thank you for that information, Counsellor Alfil; "The One Across the Board" won't like that one bit. Sir Caballo, to f6 at once!
Absolutely out of the question, Sire! Someone spilled cola there, and I am not going to stand in that wet muck with my clean felt.
If need be I'll capture on f8, because that looks nice and dry.

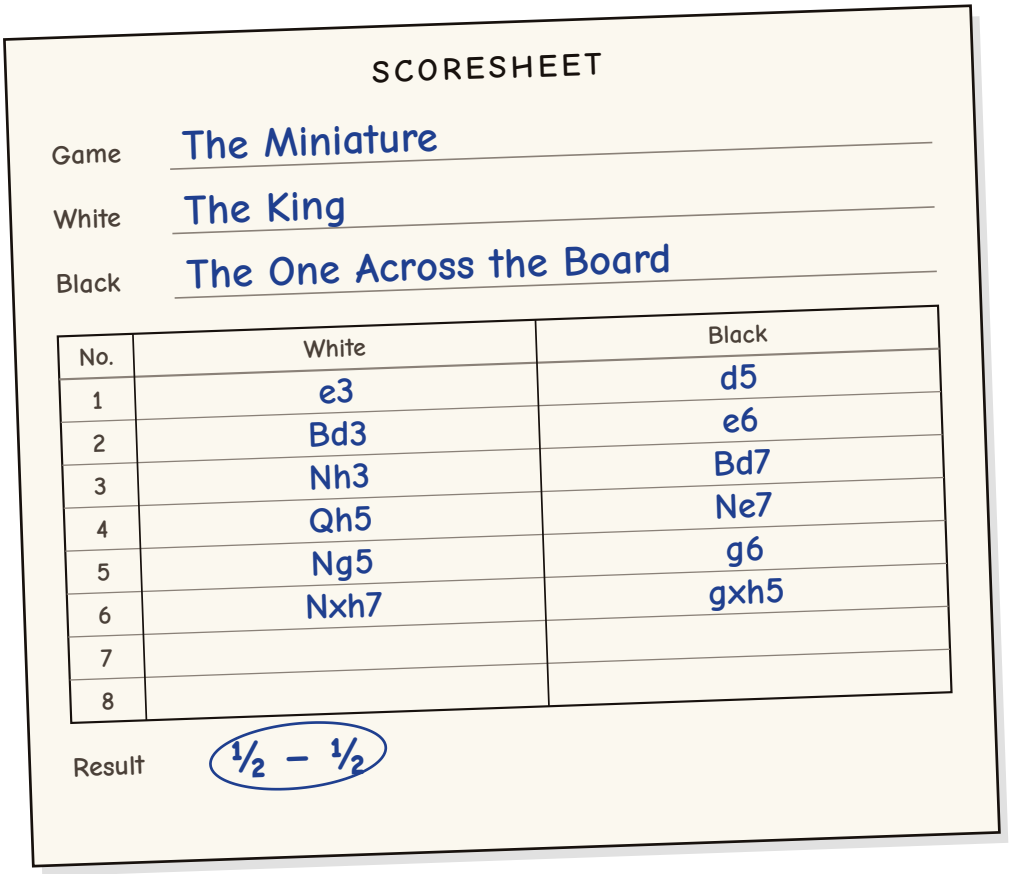

(=) ?
By the way, "The One Across the Board" is offering a draw.




Accept it, then.


1/2 - 1/2

A few weeks later
the chess club bought
new boards.



Text: Sven Gorts, based on the article De Miniatuur (2012)
Drawings: Claude (Anthropic)
Typeface: Comic Neue
First English edition, October 2026
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At the chess club there is a board that has survived quite a few games. The pieces know it like the back of their hand: every square, every corner, every spot where you would rather not stand.

Today the white king wants to shine. He has a plan, an opening and an unshakeable faith in himself. Only his subjects have their own ideas about that.

For what do you do when you have to obey orders on a board you would rather not set foot on?

A modern farce about pride, stubbornness and good advice that nobody wants to hear, played by the pieces themselves.

The Miniature